gods Indra, Varuna, Mitra and Nasatya. The Mittani appear to have been a military elite who ruled over the Hurrian people living in northern Iraq and Syria. There are records of their dealings with Egyptians, Hitties and the Assyrians. From their names and gods, we can tell that the Mittani were outsiders who had entered the region from the east. Yet again, we have evidence of a westward movement that confounds the traditional view that Vedic people moved eastward into India rather than the other way around. The peacocks that recur in Mittani art tell of a people who remember not just their gods but also the fauna of the land they left.

Amazingly, faint memories of these times remain alive among the secretive and much persecuted Yezidi people. The Yezidi are a tiny religious group of around 150,000 adherents who live among the Kurds of northern Iraq, eastern Turkey and parts of Armenia. Their religion has ancient pagan roots, albeit with an overlay of Islamic, Christian and Zoroastrian influence. They faced centuries of persecution, especially under Ottoman rule, for being ‘devil worshippers’. Like Hindus, the Yezidis believe in reincarnation and avatars, they pray facing the sun at dawn and dusk, and have a system of endogamous castes. Their temples with conical spires look strikingly similar to Hindu temples. The ‘Peacock Angel’ (Tawuse Melek) plays a central role in the religion.[27] The peacock is a native to the Indian subcontinent and is not found naturally in Yezidi lands. Is it possible that the Yezidis have somehow preserved an ancient link to India? Indeed, the Yezidi themselves have a tradition that they came to the Middle East from India about 4000 years ago—around when the mature Harappan civilization would have begun to disintegrate or perhaps the Battle of the Ten Kings took place. Does one of these events explain the spread of R1a1, the genetic lineage that we discussed in the previous chapter?

The world of the Harappans and the Rig Veda dissolved as the Saraswati dried. No matter what one thinks of the Harappan–Vedic debate, two things are clear. First, geography and the forces of nature played an important role in the evolution of Indian history. Second, the subcontinent has witnessed a great deal of migration and churn. People, ideas and trade have moved in